

MALACHIAS

THE PROPHECY OF MALACHIAS.

PREFACE.

Malachias, whose name signifies "the angel of the Lord," was contemporary with Nehemias, and by some is believed to have been the same person with Esdras. He was the last of the prophets, in the order of time, and flourished about four hundred years before Christ. He foretells the coming of Christ; the reprobation of the Jews and their sacrifices; and the calling of the Gentiles, who shall offer up to God in every place an acceptable sacrifice. Ch. --- He also clearly speaks of the twofold coming of Christ, preceded by the Baptist and by Elias. Nothing is known for certain respecting this prophet. He inveighs against the same crimes as Nehemias, to whose covenant he alludes, C. ii. 4.

None was afterwards recognized for a prophet till the Baptist appeared. C. ---

Both priests and people are here reproved, and the Jewish law yields to that of Christ. W. --- No date is prefixed no more than to the works of Jonas, Nahum,

&c. S. Jerom seems to fix on the seventh year of Artaxerxes, when Esdras came to Jerusalem. Liber ejus pro titulo sit. H.

MALACHIAS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Malachias, "the angel of the Lord." S. Jerom always reads Malachi, "my angel." Sept.

"his angel;" whence Origen infers, that this was an angel incarnate. C.

Ver. 2. Loved us. So they thought, (Theod.) and perhaps spoke. H. --- Jacob. I have preferred his posterity, to make them my chosen people,

and to load them with my blessings, without any merit on their part, and though they have been always ungrateful; whilst I have rejected Esau, and executed severe judgments upon his posterity. Not that God punished Esau or his posterity beyond their deserts, but that by his free election and grace he loved Jacob, and favoured his posterity above their deserts. See the annotations upon Rom.

ix. Ch. --- Neither deserved any thing. God's choice was gratuitous, both with respect to the fathers and their offspring. W.

Ver. 3. Esau, perceiving the evil which was already in him, and would appear afterwards; (S. Jer.

and Theod.) or rather he was a figure of the reprobate, though not of course one himself. S. Aug.

--- A person is said to hate what he loves less. Esau's privileges were transferred to his brother, who enjoyed a much finer country, and was chosen for God's peculiar inheritance. C. ---

Temporal blessings are here specified. --- Dragons. Sept. "houses;" so that they shall be deserted.

H. --- Edom was ravaged by Nabuchodonosor. The people retired into the cities, from which the Jews were driven. Yet afterwards they rebuilt their own habitations.

Ver. 4. Down, by the Machabees, who forced the people to receive circumcision. 1 Mac. v. 3. C.

--- At that time the Jews were more pious, and glorified God. H. --- Ever. God's gratuitous love appears in his leaving Edom in captivity, and restoring the Jews. W.

Ver. 6. Father. God sometimes took this title. Ex. iv. 32. But he was oftener represented as a master; and the old law was a law of fear. C. --
- Servant et mertuunt jus. Juv. xiv.

Ver. 7. Bread, including all the victims, &c. Lev. iii. 11. Num. xxviii. 2. C. --- By vile presents they shew their contempt of God. W.

Ver. 8. Lame. The victims must be without defect. Lev. xxii. 21. Those of the Jews were also rendered inadmissible by their evil dispositions. Agg. ii. 14. It is surprising, that after such scourges they should not have been more upon their guard. The negligence of the sacred ministers, is a sure sign of faith being extinct. C. --- Pagans often thus treated thier idols. Clem.

Strom. vi. --- Prince: the governor sent by the Persians. If you dare not make such presents to men of eminence, how shall I accept them? C. --- How dare you offer them to me? W.

Ver. 10. Gratis? Are you not well paid? Why then perform you not your duty exactly? C. ---

Sept. "Wherefore also among you shall the doors be shut, and my altar is not enkindled for nought," (H.) as if God menaced the Jews with the rejection of the temple, as the sequel does. C.

--- Pleasure. Many other prophets had foretold the reprobation of the synagogue, but none more plainly. The reason is also assigned, viz. the ingratitude and repeated sins of the people, on which account the Gentiles of all countries shall be chosen. W.

Ver. 11. Sacrifice. Prot. "incense." H. --- Clean oblation. The precious body and blood of Christ in the eucharistic sacrifice. Ch. --- This is denoted by the very word mincha, the offering of flour and wine. C. See S. Just. dial. S. Iræn.iv. 32.

S. Aug. de Civ. Dei. xviii. 35. --- "We pollute this bread, that is the body of Christ, when we approach the altar unworthily." S. Jer. v. 7.

--- This sacrifice is clean. Trid. xxii. C. i. M. --- It is offered daily throughout the world. The Jews see the completion of this prediction, and are vexed; they strive to elude its force. Though enemies, they bear about these proofs of our faith, and of their own condemnation. C. ---

God not only changed his people, but instituted a better sacrifice. Instead of the former needy elements, (Gal. iv.) which were often defiled by the sins of the offerers, He instituted the sacrifice of his own Body and Blood, under the appearance of bread and wine, as S.

Chrys. (in Ps. xcv.) Theod.

&c. prove against all opponents. A sacrifice different from any offered as many have demonstrated. W. --- Christ's bloody sacrifice on the cross was performed on Calvary, and not among the Gentiles. What sacrifice can Protestants now produce? H.

Ver. 12. It. The priests complain that Il is burnt, (Grot.) or rather they treat sacred things with contempt. C. --- They falsely pretend that they give their best, being poor. M.

Ver. 13. Behold of our labour, &c. You pretended labour and weariness, when you brought your offering; and so made it of no value, by offering it with an evil mind. Moreover, what you offered was both defective in itself, and gotten by rapine and extortion. Ch. --- These were two defects. W. --- Heb. "what fatigue, or if we change one letter, and read (C.) mothlaé, (H.) it stinks, and you." &c. Some copies of Sept. Arab. &c. "I blew them away," with disgust. ---

Rapine. Eccli. xxxiv. 24. --- Offering. Mincha, v. 11. C. --- Such victims and presents as are lame or strange, are rejected. Pliny viii. 45.

Ver. 14. Male. So better things are styled mascula thura. Virg. Pliny xii. 14. --- It was unlawful to offer a female by vow, but not out of devotion. Lev. xxii. 18. 23.

C. --- King. So the Persian monarchs were called. --- Dreadful. Gr. "Epiphanes."

H.

MALACHIAS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Priests. Such, hoarding up riches, dishonour God and his sacraments, as if they were temporal things to be purchased, and so they scandalize the weak. It would be well for them if they were reduced to poverty, (v. 2.) and would repent, as they will otherwise be deprived of eternal goods, having received their wages in this world, like hirelings. John x. W.

Ver. 2. Blessings, riches. The priests also blessed the people. Num. vi. 23. C.

Ver. 3. Shoulder. I will cast away the shoulder, which in the law was appointed to be your portion, and fling it at you in my anger: and will reject both you and your festivals like dung. Ch.

--- Heb. now reads for shoulder, zerah, "grain," or seed. C. --- "I will menace you with the shoulder, and will spread dirt on your faces, even the dirt of your feasts," (Aquila) or "the ventricle of your festivals." Sept. H.

Ver. 4. Levi. When this tribe was chosen does not appear. Some think that he alludes to the renewing of the covenant under Nehemias, which seems best. 2

Esd. ix. 1. 38. I then promised you life, &c. C.

Ver. 7. The angel, viz. the minister and messenger. Ch. --- Priests must administer the sacraments, and likewise instruct the people, being God's messengers. W. --- The Jews were well acquainted with the law. Jer. xviii. 18. ---

The priests had to decide most intricate cases. Deut.

xvii. 9. and xxxiii. 9. C. --- The sentence of the high priest was received like that of an angel.

Diod. Sic. xl. apud Phol. --- If such science was required under the old law, how much more is necessary in Christian priests, whose mysteries and duties are so much more important! C. ---

Ignoratio scripturarum ignoratio Christi est. S. Jer. in Is. & hic.

Ver. 9. People. If priests comply not with these high functions, they are despicable here, and condemned to eternal torments. Jude 11. W. --- Accepted.

Heb. "raised up faces," instead of reproving the guilty. Deut. i. 10. Lev. xix 15.

Ver. 10. Brother, in distress. 2 Esd. v. 1. S. Jerom mentions the tradition of the Jews, which supposed that the captives at their return dismissed their wives, and married young ones, though strangers. v. 11. But this is not probable.

Such women were ordered to be dismissed. 1 Esd. ix.

1. and 2 Esd. xiii. 23. C.

Ver. 11. God, or one addicted to idol-worship, (H.) which was contrary to the law. Deut. vii. 3.

C. --- Sept. "the holy things of the Lord, by what he has loved and done for strange gods." H.

Ver. 12. Master. Heb. "the watcher, and him who answers," on guard. C. ---

Sept. "doth such things, till he be tumbled out," &c. --- Him. Sept. "and out of those who offer a sacrifice to," &c.

Such people shall be excluded from the society of God's servants. H.

Ver. 13. With tears; viz. by occasion of your wives, whom you have put away, and who came to weep and lament before the altar. Ch. --- Though divorces were tolerated, (Mat. xix. 6.) the more virtuous did

not approve of them, particularly when a wife is put away who had been married in youth. See v. 10.

Perhaps this corruption had crept in, like others, (C.) owing to the people's commerce with strangers. Diod. in Photius.

Ver. 14. Covenant. The order established at first. Gen. ii. 24. Prov. ii. 17. The parties promised fidelity to each other.

Ver. 15. His spirit. Eve received a soul from God, like Adam. Heb. "One (Abraham, Chal.

styled one, Ezec. xxxiii. 24.) did it not, and he had the," &c. Sept. vary. The text is very obscure.

C. See Cap. Crit. iv. p. 317. Grabe prol. --- A strange god did not make women.

The human race is best propagated, where polygamy and divorces are rejected. H.

Ver. 16. Garment; viz. of every man that putteth away his wife without just cause; notwithstanding that God permitted it in the law, to prevent the evil of murder. Ch. --- The original may receive this sense; or the woman must blame herself if she were hateful, (Deut. xxiv.

1.) and the man acted not treacherously. C. --- Sept. "iniquity shall cover your thoughts." H. ---

It should be "garments," endumata, though S. Jerom and the printed edit. read enthumemata, (C.)

"thoughts." The first part contains the objection, and the second God's reply.

S. Jer. H.

Ver. 17. Judgment. Being scandalized at the prosperity of the wicked, (H.) they deny Providence. Ps. lxxii. Jer. xii. C. --- Yet the wicked are

left for wise purposes, either for their amendment, or for the trial of the just. S. Aug. Ps. liv.

--- Those who are offended at their present success, (H.) think not of judgment nor of eternal goods. S. Jer.

MALACHIAS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. My angel, viz. John the Baptist, the messenger of God, and forerunner of Christ. Ch. ---

His purity and office procure him this title. W. --- Afterwards Christ himself shall come, for the ruin and for the resurrection of many. Lu. ii. 34. Hence threats and promises are intermixed. The evangelists read his face, making the Father speak, whereas the Son is introduced by the prophet, who however presently changes the person. It is all the same which person of the blessed Trinity speaks, as all act together. C. --- Testament. The Messias, the mediator of the covenant with mankind, (W.) with Abraham, and Moses. The latter calls him the prophet; (Deut. xviii. 18.) and Zacharias, alluding to this text, explains angel in the same sense. Lu. i. 76. --- Temple. The ancient Jews were convinced that the Messias would come to the temple of Zorobabel, and be its chief glory. Agg. ii. 8. C. --- Their descendants put off the coming for some long time, though the prophet says presently, or on a sudden. S. Jer. Basnage vi.

26. --- Some take this temple to be the womb of the bless Virgin. S. Cyr. S. Aug.

de Civ. Dei. xviii. 35. C. --- The Baptist was conceived, born, and preached first; and shortly after Christ appeared. W.

Ver. 2. Coming. This may be explained of the Baptist, (Lu. iii. 7.) or of the second coming of Christ; though his first coming shewed the hypocrisy of the Jews. They would not acknowledge him, but sought his death, and brought on their own condemnation. C. --- Fuller's. Sept.

"washers' herb." Borith is found in all the low places of Palestine, (S. Jer.) and probably denotes soda, (Jer. ii. 22. C.) or fullers' earth. H. --- Christ purified the religion of the Jews, or did what was requisite for that purpose. The people would not obey. Yet he established his Church in all purity.

Ver. 3. Justice. This is spoken of the Christian priesthood, which far excels that of Levi, Heb. v.

and vii. &c. C. --- Many Jewish priests embraced the gospel. Acts vi. 7. H.

Ver. 4. Years. So in the mass we beg that God would receive the sacrifice, "as he received the presents of Abel." M.

Ver. 5. Judgment. He has answered (v. 1, 2) the complaint of the Jews. C. ii. 17.

H. --- This he does here (M.) more pointedly. H. --- Christ condemned the world, as his spirit did likewise. Jo.

xvi. 8. He made an example of Jerusalem, which shewed that he would not leave crimes unpunished. We may also understand this of his last coming. C.

--- God threatens to punish even secret sins, which are know to him alone. W.

Ver. 6. Change. Heb. also, (H.) "hate or recommence." I do not strike the fallen.

Did I spare Sennacherib? &c. Have I not protected the posterity of Jacob? How then can you say that I am indifferent about human affairs? C. --- Consumed.

Sept. "you depart not from the sins of your fathers. You have rejected my," &c.

Ver. 8. Afflict. Lit. "pierce." Sept. "supplant," (H.) or kick at. 1 K. ii. 29. But the term applied to Heli is different. Here it signifies to nail or irritate. C. --- Tithes: the payment is most strictly commanded. W.

Ver. 9. Want. Heb. "malediction." S. Jerom specifies the kind. C. --- Sept. "and you obstinately turn away your eyes, and supplant me," &c. H.

Ver. 10. Heaven; copious showers. --- Blessing; fertility.

Ver. 11. Devour; locusts and other vermin. M. --- Malachias came later than Aggeus, and probably speaks of a different famine, to which the Jews were exposed for neglecting to pay tithes. C. --- How many now work on holydays, as if all depended on their labour and not on God's blessing! H.

Ver. 14. Vain. Murmuring against God is blasphemous and unsufferable. When the Jews were punished by famine, for neglecting to pay tithes, they laid the blame on God, as if he took more care of other nations which had abundance.

W. --- Sorrowful: "humbled." Chal. "in mourning."

Jun. --- But it seems to denote downcast countenances, which our Saviour orders his disciples not to affect. Mat. vi. 16. C.

Ver. 15. Proud. Sept. "strange." H. --- Z has been take for u. --- Built up: have a numerous family, (C.) and abundance. --- Tempted. Sept. "resisted."

Ver. 16. Then. Grabe changes tauta, these things, into tote, then. The Sept.

make the pious express the former sentiments. H. --- David, Jeremias, &c. had experienced such anxiety. Ps.

lxxii. 2. C. --- According to the Heb. &c. the just hearing such blasphemies, doubt not but God will mark them in the book (H.) of his

justice, and punish them.

Ver. 17. Possession; (peculium) the property of a slave. C. --- Such look upon the smallest things with eagerness. Heb. segula, (H.) means some precious thing. C. --- Spare. Sept. "chose,"

&c. H.

MALACHIAS 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Furnace. At the day of judgment, the difference between the just and the wicked will plainly appear. W. --- This sense is most generally given, as well as to those words where our Saviour speaks of the signs of the destruction of Jerusalem and of the end of the world together.

Mat. xxiv. 3. Lu. xxi. 5. Yet the prophet may also allude to the punishment of the Jews by the Romans, when all were assembled at the Passover, (C.) a scourge which the Christians escaped by retiring to Pella. Eus. Hist. iii. 5. --- Proud.

Sept. "strangers." C. --- Branch. No hope shall remain. M.

Ver. 2. Wings. The sun is represented with wings, to imply celerity. The appearance of the Lord will be most acceptable to the virtuous. C. --- Look up, for your redemption is at hand. Lu. xxi.

28. --- Herd. Prot. "stall." Heb. marbek, (H.) "fattened;" though some explain it of oxen treading out corn: they would not however leap, nor fatten so much. C.

Ver. 3. Ashes, burnt in Jerusalem. H. --- Christians rejoiced in the execution of divine justice.

The Jews were not allowed to approach the new city, Elia. S. Jer.

Ver. 4. Law. This must be your guide and comfort. No more prophets shall appear before the Baptist. C.

Ver. 5. Elias. Sept. add, "the Thesbite;" and S. Jerom (in Mat. xvii.) says, that Elias shall indeed come and restore all things. --- Dreadful. Christ's first coming was in all meekness; but he will judge in terror. Hence the prophet's meaning is not that S. John, but that Elias shall come before the great day of the Lord. W. --- Yet we may understand it of Christ coming into the world to preach, and again to judge. His first coming proved terrible to the perfidious Jews, whose ruin presently ensued. The destruction of Jerusalem was a figure of that which the world shall experience. C. --- This shall be preceded by the preaching of Elias. N. Alex. Diss.vi. --- This interpretation seems very striking and natural, though the prophet may have had the first coming of Christ and the ruin of the city chiefly in view. Our Saviour testifies that the Elias whom the Jews expected was already come. Mat. xi. 14. and xvii. 11. Lu. ix. 8. C.

Ver. 6. Heart, &c. By bringing over the Jews to the faith of Christ, he shall reconcile them to their fathers, viz. the patriarchs and prophets, whose hearts for many ages have been turned away from them, because of their refusing to believe in Christ. C. --- The antipathy of Jews and Gentiles shall cease. Both shall enter the Church of Christ. Is. xi. 13. The Baptist strove to ameliorate the manners of the people, and to bring all to Christ, who reconciles all seeming contradictions in the Scriptures. He came to put an end to all dissensions. C.

--- Yet the wicked will still have war. Mat. x. 35. H. --- Christ will convert those Jews at last, (Rom. xi. 26. C.) who have not yet opened their eyes. Their fathers, the apostles and first converts, have long ago shewn them the example. H. --- Anathema. In the Hebrew, cherem, that is, utter destruction. Ch.

--- Sept. "entirely," (C.) or "suddenly;" arden. S. Jer. Deut. vii. 26. --- This passage intimates that the ruin of Jerusalem is threatened. If people should be converted, would that stop the general conflagration? C. --- Some of our crafty adversaries have inferred from the above explanation of anathema, that the Church means heretics to be destroyed: but her kingdom is not of this world: she speaks only of the soul, and exercises a spiritual power. H.